DMC welcome letter

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Hello everybody,

Welcome to "Tales of Defiance to Mind Control in the Modern Age," or "DMC" for short. I am looking forward to our learning together. I welcome your arguments, alternatives, and even complaints.

We meet in person on Mondays during Period 2 (11:10 a.m. to 12:35 p.m.) at 51 Sawyer Road, second floor. Our class meets on November 2, 9, 16, 23, and 30.

Please feel free to contact me at axelrod@alumni.princeton.edu with comments, questions, requests for clarification or help, or to let me know if you will be late or absent for a class.

To help me verify that everyone's email address works and to begin getting to know one another, please reply to this note with a brief email that includes your name, the town where you live, what sparked your interest in taking this class, and any background information you would like to share. If you are comfortable doing so, please include a picture of yourself to help me connect faces with names. Please also indicate if there is any information in your response that you do not want me to share with the class. I will combine the authorized information into a single email, which I plan to send to the class on November 1.

For each of the first four weeks, we will focus on a different tale of defiance to mind control. The final week will be devoted to discussion of the arc of all four stories as a whole.

Website

Here is a link to the course website: course website. Parts of the website are under construction, but all the materials needed to prepare for Week 1 are available now. With the exception of personal information about students, such as the information in the "single email" mentioned above, all class materials will be accessible from the website.

The website has a header and a page that appears in a frame below the header. The header has a dropdown box in the upper left that allows one to select the page that appears in the frame below the header.

Email

When I email links to course website pages, I will send links to the standalone pages, without the course header.

I will send all essential materials (other than the films to watch) by email. For example, this email is cut and paste from the Welcome Letter on the website. The course syllabus, the course preface, and my Notes on *Notes from the Underground*, which are all assigned for week 1, are attached as pdf files.

An Arc of Stories and Lenses

Each of the four stories we will explore could be the basis of one or more full courses. Combining them means we won't be able to cover the individual stories in great depth, but it will allow us to see an example of what I call *an* arc of dystopian stories. For each story, I will suggest a tool or "lens" we can use to examine it. These lenses are intended to foster thinking and discussion, not to create a barrier of abstraction.

Week 1 Homework

The homework to prepare for our first class is the following, which is copied from the Week1 page. I have attached PDF versions of the Week1, Syllabus, Preface, and Notes on *Notes from the Underground* pages.

- Read the Course Syllabus
  - Check that you will have access to the three films and story in the Course Materials section.
- Read the Preface to the Course, which consists of sections:
  1. Genesis of the Course: Getting Perspective on Mind Control
  2. Shaping the Container
  3. What We Will Be Exploring
  4. An Arc of Stories and Lenses
     - You may delay reading the parts on the tales for weeks 2, 3, and 4, which will be repeated as part of the notes on the tale of the week.
- Read the Notes on *Notes from the Underground*.
  - This contains a section titled "Tale 1: Notes from the Underground", which exactly repeats the subsection by that name in section 4 of the preface.
- Watch "Notes from the Underground", one man show starring Larry Cedar, free on YouTube.



Questions

Here are some questions that may help guide your reflection.

Relating to the Course Preface

- What do we mean by "mind control"? Where's the line between influence, persuasion, socialization, and control?
- Is there such a thing as a truly autonomous, unconditioned self? Or is the "authentic self" we want to protect also a social construction?
- Why might fiction be a better tool than a lecture or essay for helping us *feel* what mind control is like from the inside?
- As we move across these four works, control shifts from external force to something we welcome. Does control become more effective as it becomes more comfortable?

- What personality traits make someone more or less susceptible to each kind of control? Where would you place yourself?

Relating to human outlier analysis

- How is the protagonist unusual in the society in which they live, and how are they trying to influence that society?
- Do you sympathize with the protagonist and his plight? What about the other characters?
- Can we usefully separate out the dysfunction from the creative insight?
- What does the protagonist see about society that those around him do not see?

Specific to Notes from the Underground

- The Underground Man rejects the idea that humans are rational actors. Why does he insist on the freedom to act against his own interest? Is spite a form of liberty?
- Are feeling and complexity suppressed by naive rationalism?

- Is rationalism actually a form of mind control, or is that a misdiagnosis?
- Who decides which people in society are outliers to be shunned, which thoughts are "crazy" and which are sane?
- The Underground Man is miserable, self-sabotaging, and often unlikable. Does his defiance actually free him, or does it just trap him in a different prison?
- When is being unhinged and spiteful a useful choice in a modern democracy?
- The Underground Man is struggling to escape from his mousehole. He resents "2+2=4" logic being forced on him, but he is trapped into incessant, intelectuallized monologuing from within his cave (mousehole). Are love and faith of some kind the best ways to escape the cave of rational egoism?

Connecting "Notes from the Underground" to today's world of AI and social media

- The Underground Man rebels against being treated as a predictable input-output machine. Recommendation engines and predictive analytics treat us exactly that way—as behavior to be forecast. Is refusing to be predictable still a meaningful act of freedom when the algorithm has already modeled your refusal?
- Where in your own online life do complexity and messiness get suppressed in favor of a cleaner, curated, presentable self?
- Educational, religious, and other institutions have traditionally set norms of what thoughts and actions are acceptable. Outliers have been sent to prisons and mental asylums. How are those roles evolving in today's age of social media and AI?

Questioning the Teacher

- Is my style of presentation constructive, or even coherent, for you?
- What questions would you like to see discussed in class?

I look forward to hearing from you and seeing you in class,
Scott Axelrod